> **NOTE** Istio identities are based on Kubernetes *service accounts*, which are distinct from services. By default, there is only a single service account in each namespace, shared by all pods in that namespace. See https://kubernetes.io/docs/tasks/configure-pod-container/configure-service-account/ for instructions on how to create separate service accounts and associate them with your pods.

Istio also has its own version of Kubernetes' ingress controller, in the form of the *Istio Gateway*. The gateway allows external traffic into the service mesh and can also be configured to process egress traffic leaving the service mesh.[5] The gateway can also be configured to accept TLS client certificates from external clients, in which case it will also set the `X-Forwarded-Client-Cert` header (and strip it from any incoming requests). The gateway sets the same fields as the Istio sidecar proxies, but also sets the Cert field with the full encoded certificate.

Because a request may pass through multiple Istio sidecar proxies as it is being processed, there may be more than one client certificate involved. For example, an external client might make a HTTPS request to the Istio gateway using a client certificate, and this request then gets forwarded to a microservice over Istio mTLS. In this case, the Istio sidecar proxy's certificate would overwrite the certificate presented by the real client and the microservice would only ever see the identity of the gateway in the `X-Forwarded-Client-Cert` header. To solve this problem, Istio sidecar proxies don't replace the header but instead append the new certificate details to the existing header, separated